moment too late, Akbar – ‘the greater’ – was born.

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Akbar was not Humayun’s first son. Almost exactly fourteen years before, when Humayun was still discharging his duties in Badakhshan, he had a son whom he named Al-Aman. When news of this was brought to Babur in Agra, the emperor was displeased. Never particularly impressed with Humayun’s literary instincts (he once wrote a letter to his son ticking him off for his convoluted style), Babur didn’t like this newfangled name. It was unusual to prefix ‘al’ to a name, and even if Al-Aman meant ‘peace’ or ‘security’ in Arabic, in the family’s native Turki it could easily be misheard as ‘alaman’, ‘plunderer’ or ‘ilaman’, ‘I do not feel’.[52] It was hardly the kind of name a conqueror would want for his grandson; and, besides, it was entirely inappropriate for Humayun to name the boy without Babur’s approval.

In a cold-hearted aside on the subject, Abul Fazl writes that displeasing one’s father can bring about ‘a hundred evils, external and internal’. Indeed, the infant died.

Once Humayun became emperor himself, his mother, Maham Begum, developed a burning desire for a grandson, such that, in Gulbadan’s words, any ‘good-looking and nice girl’ she spotted was immediately recruited to the task. Amongst these was Maywa-jaan. Dutifully, Humayun married her. Three days later, Humayun’s first wife, Bega Begum, arrived in Agra from Kabul – and was soon pregnant. Unhappy to lose her limelight, Maywa-jaan declared herself with child too, sending Maham Begum into ecstasy; she began collecting gifts while mouthing a refrain: ‘Perhaps one of them will have a son.’

As it happens, Bega Begum had a daughter. Maham Begum focused all her attentions on Maywa-jaan and the months passed by. Ten, then eleven. The young girl spoke cheerfully of an aunt who’d delivered in her twelfth month. ‘But in the end,’ writes Gulbadan ruefully, ‘everyone knew she was a fraud.’

It is easy, almost reflexive, to imagine Maham Begum flapping about in a womanly dither, to dismiss her ambitions as merely domestic. In fact, however, her impatience may have been for an heir, not a grandson –